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The specific and the ambiguous: what can we say of royal ideology of bronze coin types of the earliest Seleucid kings?

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Abstract: This article argues that the bronze coin types of the earliest Seleucid kings clearly illustrate the royal ideology of Seleucus I and his co-rulership with Antiochus I. This article considers the audience and meaning of the bronzes, as well as their minting patterns. After a discussion of the obverse and reverse types, this article focuses on two images: that of the bull and the anchor. The bull being both highly produced, and open to interpretation, and the anchor being a symbol more personal and specific to Seleucus I. This article then goes on to put forward that the bull/anchor types produced at Ai Khanoum/Bactra were a deliberate link on the part of Antiochus to the types produced by Seleucus I to create an imperial image.

Keywords: Bronze coinage, Seleucids, royal authority, minting patterns, royal ideology

The field of Seleucid numismatics is ever evolving. Recent studies have increasingly favoured a broader approach to understanding and evaluating the surviving corpus of coin types holistically. However, these studies have tended to be general, focusing on multiple different denominations, metals, broad chronological frameworks and sometimes a comparative aspect with other Diadochi – particularly Ptolemy.¹ Bronzes, especially those minted during the lifetime of Seleucus I, have therefore not garnered the kind of specific focus that they deserve. Bronze coins typically are less explored in scholarship, one reason certainly being that they are less well at-

¹ See Le Rider and de Callataÿ (2006), de Callataÿ (2014), Iossif (2015), 1–27, (2018). A comparison with the Ptolemaic dynasty is not included in this article as Ptolemy tends to refer to Alexander more in his coinage, i.e. in reverse legends, as a result of the acquisition of the body of Alexander. Additionally, the coregency period is much smaller (beginning in 285/4 BC) and does not seem to have resulted in any bronze production by the co-king Ptolemy II. See Lorber (2018), 61.

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tested in our surviving records.² This article will focus on the 65 bronze coin types minted during the reign of Seleucus I.³ It is argued here that these types and their chronological and geographical dissemination illustrate the relationship between the earliest Seleucid kings and their subjects. Bronze coins are the most useful material to examine in relation to royal ideology given both the need for authority to create them and their use as a tool for lower value economic interactions.⁴ Bronzes had the largest audience, and therefore communicated to the broadest section of society the ideology of their creator.

There are many ways of studying numismatics; this article is interested in utilising two of these. A distinction can be made between those studies interested in exploring the entire body of surviving coins, and those, particularly in reference to ideology, that wish to illustrate their argument using examples of singular coins.⁵ I have taken a mixed approach: I will survey the entire body of documented bronze coin types minted under Seleucus I and then focus more closely on the two concepts evoked in the title of this article, which are encapsulated by the two images discussed in the penultimate section: the bull (ambiguous) and the anchor (specific). First, however, I need to defend my initial statement that bronze is the most useful medium for studying royal ideology. The argument is twofold and relates to audience and minting patterns: I shall take these in turn before looking at the most common coin imagery in more detail.

2 While there is a greater quantity of silver types, their audience would have been more limited given their value. Thus, to evaluate the most widely accessible and consumed form of royal ideology on coinage, my premise here is to limit my scope to bronze types.

3 This is based on search results from the Seleucid Coins Online Database, see <http://numismatics.org/hrc/>

4 I use the term ideology rather than propaganda as I feel the latter implies a sense of deceit, whereas ideology is more neutral in terms of the aim of this paper, which is to explore the ideas and messages communicated on bronze. The term propaganda is used occasionally in Seleucid and numismatic scholarship, e.g. by Hadley (1974a) and Erickson (2019). At p. 6–8 Erickson sets out his justification for this within his introductory chapter. However, I am not convinced by his reasoning and believe the use of the term veers too much into anachronism; neither am I swayed by the recent reconsideration offered by Meister (2021). Hadley's use of the term is indebted to its usage during the Cold War.

5 See FitzGerald (2017), 37 for a good summary of these approaches in reference to Roman Imperial policy. Rowan (2012), 3–4 discusses this in reference to her work on the Severans, and Noreña (2001), 147 notes the importance of quantification. Hekster (2015), 31 notes issues regarding the study of coins in terms of their commonness within the Roman world.

I Audience and meaning

Being of little intrinsic value, bronze coins were more in need of – and hence more intimately connected to – political authority than coins made of precious metals. In addition, bronzes were a medium used for everyday financial interactions; therefore, they were a direct and accessible path on which to communicate royal authority. They should consequently give us unique insights into the construction of authority that motivated the acceptance of both coins and kings by Seleucid subjects, although the exact recipients and intended users of bronze coins are difficult to pin down. It has traditionally been assumed that bronze coins were created for a Greek audience, particularly soldiers.⁶ Whilst it is true that all the bronze coin types included in this study do include reverse legends that are in Greek (see Fig. 1), this does not mean that these coins were only read by and interacted with a Greek literate audience. Literacy within the ancient world was not all or nothing. Additionally, the bronze types investigated in this study include the proper names of Alexander, Seleucus and Antiochus, alongside the title of king(s).⁷ Given the various levels of ancient Greek literacy, it is possible that non elites and non-Greek speakers or illiterate Greek speakers may have been able to a degree to understand these reverse legends given that they are very short. These Greek words presumably could have been intelligible to an entirely illiterate audience and possibly could have been learned through other media such as oral transmissions.

Additionally, in terms of the audience of these legends, it is probable that bronze was paid to soldiers as *sitonion* (garrison payment) who then spent them within their local area. Coinage would thus be disseminated first and foremost in a military context, but just how much this might tell us is uncertain, given that the primary function of bronze coins was to be a low-value medium of exchange; once they traded hands, it is possible that they travelled naturally from military to local contexts through a variety of economic interactions.⁸ This does not necessarily

⁶ Austin (2003), 129 and Houghton (2012), 239 who link bronzes, particularly the horse and elephant images to bronzes produced for the army. These images are referential to active engagement in battle, during which horses and elephants played a role. Of course, these symbols also have wider associations outside of a military context.

⁷ This notion of levels of literacy and ability to comprehend Greek is expressed more thoroughly in Czajkowski (2017), 64–65. On literacy in the ancient world more generally, see Harris (1989), 3–24 and Beard, et al. (1991).

⁸ Greeks in the western half of the empire were more used to coined money: see Aperghis (2004), 215. For the relative newness of coinage, particularly bronze, see Houghton (2012), 235. The circulation of bronze coins has not been studied yet in reference to the Seleucid empire, but, for a more general discussion of how bronze coins might have travelled outside of their local contexts in reference to mainland Greece, Thrace and Macedonia, see Psoma (2009), 9 and especially n. 23.

mean that the intention of Seleucid authorities was for bronzes to be intelligible to a broad audience that went beyond the confines of military personnel. However, given the simplicity of their legends and the nature of their imagery (which will be discussed further below), these coin types were, in practice, intelligible to a large number of people. Although it is impossible to be certain about the intention of those responsible for the design of bronze coins, it is not unreasonable to expect that the possibility and likelihood of bronze types being seen by many different types of people would have been taken into account by those responsible for minting them.

The homogeneous nature of bronze types can support this notion: they are minted across the empire and follow similar lines in terms of imagery and language. Therefore, instead of catering to specific audiences, be they Greek soldiers or Bactrian inhabitants, these coins demonstrate the desire to create a unified message regarding Seleucid authority. Thus, messages of power and communication of royal authority on bronze were homogenous across the empire, notable changes related to new configurations of personal authority rather than to geography and the specific targeting of regional audiences. The changes in reverse legends and relationship to the construction of royal authority took place in relation to personal agency of kings rather than a concern for a specific audience. This notion of change relating to personal authority will be discussed in the next section, exploring the beginnings of bronze production and its shift between the kingship of Seleucus, and the co-kingship of Antiochus I.

II Minting patterns and royal authority

Bronze production begins in the western half of the empire after the spring of 305 BC, which can be inferred from the fact that nearly all Seleucid bronze types contain the title 'king' within the reverse legend.⁹ This observation demonstrates that bronze was inherently linked to kingship and the creation of its ideology. The exception is SC34, which does contain an abbreviation of the name Seleucus (ΣΕΑΕ; see pie chart below for reverse legends).¹⁰ This coin type (SC34) is the only example of denomination E, the smallest denomination, and it is therefore possible that this

⁹ This date of 305/4 BC can be implied from the Babylonian king list, which dates the taking of the title by Seleucus to this period, see BKL (Obv. 6). The Uruk King List also confirms this, (Rev. 6). On the Babylonian King List and its dating, see Sachs and Wiseman (1954), 202–212 and Boiy (2011), 1–12. For the Uruk King List and its contents, see <https://www.livius.org/sources/content/uruk-king-list/>. On dating methods more generally in the early Hellenistic period, see Boiy (2000), 115–121.

¹⁰ In this article I have abbreviated Seleucid Coins (Part 1) to SC.

reverse legend was chosen given the lack of space for a lengthier legend. However, this coin type is estimated to have been produced between 300 and 298 BC and therefore does not detract from the point that bronze coin production post-dates the taking of the title of ‘king’ by Seleucus.¹¹

The same is true for Antiochus in the co-regency period. Coin types in the east of the empire that name Seleucus and Antiochus as kings only begin to be produced between 285–281 BC, long after Antiochus takes the title of king in 296/4.¹² Therefore, the chronology of bronzes shows the gradual development of Antiochus’ authority and how it was demonstrated in relation to Seleucus. Interestingly, Seleucus continues to mint his name on bronzes, alongside the title of king, up until his death, mostly in the west of the Empire.¹³ As these coin types are associated with his victory in this moment, they are highly revealing of Seleucus’ relationship to the construction of his own authority, given that this is after the start of the co-regency period, and postdates the beginning of bronze coin production by Antiochus in the East (285 BC). Therefore, it is significant that these coin types and their legends communicate the authority of the king Seleucus, rather than expanding to include the name of Antiochus and an assertion of a double monarchy, as is the case in the east, during the coregency period.¹⁴ Thus, we can see through the minting patterns of bronzes and their reverse legends that Seleucus creates and sustains the sense of royal personal authority on bronzes that Antiochus reacts to as he establishes his authority in the east, as will be discussed later in this article.

¹¹ The basis of the dating of SC34 to 300–298 is that the city of Seleucia Pieria was founded by Seleucus in April of 300; see John Malalas *Chron.* 8.12 and Diod. Sic. 20.47.6–7. It is suggested that given the city bears Seleucus’ name, and was the location of his tomb and posthumous cult, that the city was intended to be a royal centre; see Houghton and Lorber (2002), 23. It is not stated explicitly why this coin type is dated to the two year period after the founding of this city, but it is listed under SC32 that it shares controls with the royal series; see Houghton and Lorber (2002), 24. Therefore, perhaps it is assumed that Seleucus founded this city, began the production of bronze types and (in this case in particular) wished to brand the smallest coin types with an abbreviation of his name, both because these coins do not have space for a lengthier legend and because it was felt most appropriate to emphasize his personal relationship with the city. It is of course noteworthy that Seleucus, or rather Seleucid administration at that time, wished to emphasize his personal power, rather than the power of kingship; the emphasis is personal power, rather than the construction of dynastic or royal power.

¹² See SC284–290. There is also one coin type that names Antiochus solely as king (SC243); this also comes from the east of the Empire, but this type might post-date our period. This article treats this as the case; Houghton and Lorber (2002), 94.

¹³ E.g. the Sardis coin types which are linked to his conquest of the area: SC6–8; this final type comes from Magnesia ad Maeandrum, but is also associated with the victory at Sardis.

¹⁴ I.e. the reverse legends for SC6 and SC8 are listed under A. on Fig. 1 and SC7 has the reverse legend listed under B.

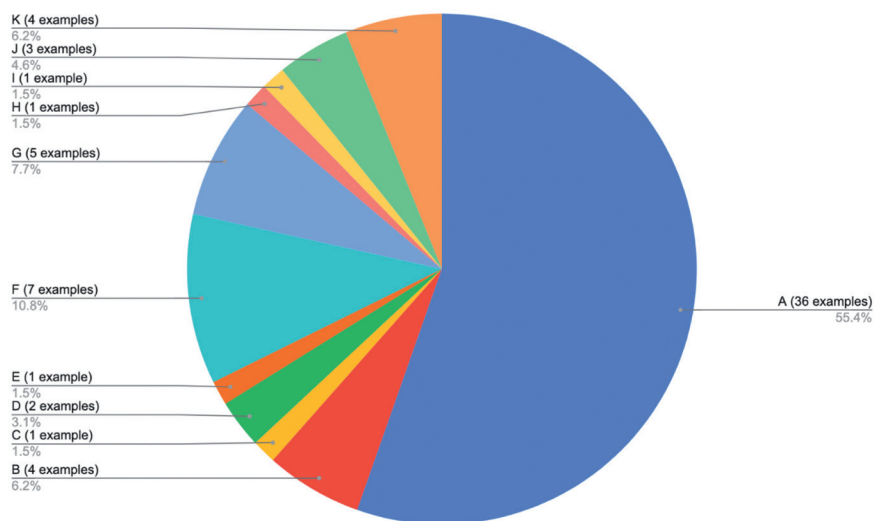


Fig. 1: Reverse legends (with their quantity and corresponding percentage)

List of corresponding reverse legends:

- A. ΒΑΣΙΛΕΩΣ ΣΕΛΕΥΚΟΥ 36 (55.3 %)¹⁵
- B. ΒΑ ΣΕ 4 (6.2 %)
- C. ΒΑΣΙ ΣΕΛΕΥ 1 (1.5 %)
- D. ΣΕΛΕΥΚΟΥ ΒΑΣΙΛΕΩΣ 2 (3.1 %)
- E. ΣΕΛΕ 1 (1.5 %)
- F. ΣΕΛΕΥΚΟΥ ΒΑΣΙΛΕΩΣ 7 (10.8 %)
- G. ΑΛΕΞΑΝΔΡΟΥ 5 (7.7 %)
- H. Not provided in database or catalogue 1 (1.5 %: SC284)
- I. ΒΑΣΙΛΕΩΣ ΑΝΤΙΟΧΟΥ 1 (1.5 %)
- J. ΒΑΣΙΛΕΩΣ ΣΕΛΕΥΚΟΥ ΑΝΤΙΟΧΟΥ 3 (4.6 %)
- K. ΒΑΣΙΛΕΩΣ ΣΕΛΕΥΚΟΥ ΑΝΤΙΟΧΟΥ 4 (6.2 %)

Only a small number of bronze types do not fit this pattern (title of king/s and personal name/s) easily: this is the so-called Alexander group (G. with the reverse legend ΑΛΕΞΑΝΔΡΟΥ), all types of which are dated to after 305 (SC222, SC190, SC189, SC188 and SC223). These coins show the portrait of Alexander and are minted in his name. They are the only types where Seleucus and/or Antio-

¹⁵ SC217, the legend is described as illegible in the online database, however- it is listed as legend A- in the catalogue; see Houghton and Lorber (2002), 102, entry for SC217.

chus are not named on bronze coinage (see Fig.1). Three of these five coin types depict the anchor reverse type, and the other two types depict *Nike* on the reverse.¹⁶ These two images are normally associated with Victory (the *Nike* type) and the personal symbol of Seleucus (the anchor type). All five of this group of coins depict Alexander's portrait with elephant headdress on the obverse.¹⁷ Therefore, they have been associated with the display of Seleucus' victory at the battle of Ipsos.¹⁸

Continued adherence to the Alexander tradition was one way of claiming authority in a post-Alexander world, but it was not the most promising path towards establishing a new, dynastic claim to power. Perhaps here with the Alexander group, in contrast to the Sardis group we see a shift in how Seleucus portrays himself in times of victory. Earlier in his reign at the battle of Ipsos, he communicates his legitimacy through adherence to Alexander, whereas by the end of his reign, after the capture of Sardis he emphasises his personal power through evoking his name and title of king. Thus, through these contrasting coin type groups and their chronology within Seleucus' reign, we can see a shift in the demonstration of personal power as represented on coin types associated with battles. Moreover, in reference to coin types that can be securely linked to military contexts we can see how at first Seleucus communicates his royal ideology through Alexander and then

¹⁶ See SC188, SC190, and SC223 for the anchor reverse types and SC222 and SC189 for the Nike type.

¹⁷ The elephant headdress is ripe for multiple interpretations: it can be seen as a connection to the East of the empire where elephants were more prominent, given the place of the elephants within battle, and the god Dionysus as he is known for his activities in the east, especially India. Additionally, Seleucus was personally tied to the east and particularly elephants given his involvement in war with Chandragupta Maurya. After this conflict there was a pact made between the two powers and Seleucus was gifted war elephants and riders. This took place between 307 and c. 305, therefore the news and symbolism of the elephant would have travelled to this western area of the empire: see Houghton and Lorber (2002), xxxiii; for a timeline and on the symbolism of the elephant within reference to Seleucus personally, see Kosmin (2014), 3 and 11–12. Ogden (2017), 17 notes that elephants were crucial to Seleucus' victory at Ipsus, therefore, this choice of headdress might have been more indicative of his victory more recently at Ipsos and less recently in the east, rather than a more general reference to Dionysus. Ancient sources: Diod. Sic. 20.106.3–5, 113.4, 21.1.1–6, Just. *Epit.* 15.4, Plut. *Demetr.* 28–30, Paus. 1.6.7. The image of Alexander in the elephant headdress was also deployed earlier in the period by Ptolemy, adding weight to the argument that these images were intended to be interpreted as Alexander: see Lorber (2018), 48; on horned imagery of Alexander deployed more generally by Ptolemy, see the section 'numismatic iconography', p. 46–59.

¹⁸ See Iossif and Lorber (2010), 156–157.

by the end of his reign, when his power is more secure, he communicated his personal power through his own name and title. However, when it comes to iconographic choices, the bull and the anchor are indeed much more prominent, and it is these that we shall now turn to.¹⁹

III The specific and the ambiguous

When we consider early Seleucid bronzes in terms of their imagery, it stands out that the most common themes are animals, divine figures, and objects (see Fig. 2 and Fig. 3).²⁰ Seleucus and Antiochus don't appear on bronzes, but other Diadochi, such as Ptolemy I, do appear on their bronzes.²¹ However, the name Seleucus and the title of king(s) appears on nearly all the bronze coinage of this period, so it can be asserted that Seleucid royal authority was meant to be viewed in conjunction with the images on bronze.²² We will also have to consider the possibility that these images, alongside their legends, had to demonstrate authority, given the lack of inherent value and their foreign (Greek) nature, as an economic token.²³

To understand the ideology in the imagery of these coin types, I will focus on two images, the anchor and the bull. They appear separate in most of their instances

19 Alexander of course being a figure much more commonly deployed by Ptolemy, Erickson (2013), Iossif (2004), Smith (1996), 203–204, Mørkholm (1991).

20 On the symbolic importance of the animals depicted, see Hoover (2011) for the bull; Kosmin (2014), 4–3 and 32–37 for the elephant; Wójcikowski (2020) for the horned horse; and Ogden (2017) 77, 109, 162 for the boar. In terms of deities, see Erickson (2019), 36–39, 62–71 on Seleucus' connections with Zeus. Interestingly, Apollo is often associated with the Nabû; see Erickson (2011), and Erickson and Wright (2011). However, the reverse types of the Apollo coins depict a variety of images that tie the image of Apollo more closely with the Greek tradition such as Athena (SC15–17), the tripod (SC17–18) and the cithara (SC20). Apollo is said to be the inventor of the Cithara, see Paus. 5.14.8; tripods were also associated with Apollo as well as carrying associations with the oracle at Delphi, mythical stories and was a victory prize in athletic events, see Neer (2001), 296. This is relevant to my discussion later on the intended interpretation of images as being broad-speaking to many different religious sensibilities, given that Apollo/Nabû seems to be more closely aligned to a Greek reading of later silver coin types.

21 This of course being with the caveat that there is some debate around the identification of the Alexander group portrait. For the purposes of my argument, and as stated previously, I have taken the position that the Alexander group portrait is intended to be identified as Alexander given the presence of his name within the reverse legend.

22 This is except for the Alexander group, see SC188–190, SC222 and SC228, and the coin types that name Antiochus solely as king within the reverse legend, see SC243.

23 Austin (2003), 129.

in the sole regency period of Seleucus (305-296/4 BC) and come together on most of the coin types produced in the east after the start of the coregency period (296/4–281), when Antiochus is tasked with the eastern half of the empire.²⁴ I will outline the various associations of these images and how we might elucidate their meanings. At the end of this section, I will discuss how Antiochus brings them together, tying the ambiguous image of strength and piety in reference to his father and his reign in the symbol of the anchor.

The image of the bull is the most common image on Seleucid bronzes, appearing on 43% of all coin types (making up 35.4% of reverse types, or 23 out of 65 examples and 7.7% of obverse types or five out of 65 examples, see Figs. 2 and 3). The bull image was minted across the empire, for example, in Antioch, Seleucia on the Tigris (both workshops), Susa, Ecbatana, Ai Khanoum, Sardis, and Magnesia ad Maeandrum. Thus, it appears to have been produced at seven out of twelve known minting locations for bronze (see Fig. 4 for mints and their productivity). Therefore, we can assert that the image of the bull was important given its ubiquity within the extant numismatic record and the variety of mostly obverse types with which it is shown in conjunction.²⁵ It was also common across the chronological period that we are discussing, first appearing on coinage as early as c. 300 and continuing to be produced up until the final year of Seleucus' reign (281).²⁶ The bull was thus intended to be relevant and easily intelligible throughout our period of interest and the imperial territory in which it was produced.

²⁴ Engels (2017), 104. It is these five types that I choose to focus on given that they make up the majority of the coin types produced under Antiochus in the east, i.e. 5 out of 7. Therefore, these types best serve to illustrate the path of inquiry this article is interested in exploring, namely the creation of royal authority from Seleucus to Antiochus.

²⁵ Erickson (2019), 50.

²⁶ There are only three coin types that have their earliest date of production beginning in 305 and these are two Apollo/horned horse types (SC112–113) and one coin type that shows Athena on the obverse and a warrior on the reverse; its mint of production is unknown, hence it is dated to 305–281, due to the presence of the reverse legend ΒΑΣΙΛΕΩΣ ΣΕΛΕΥΚΟΥ (SC303). The bull also appears on the bronze coinage produced during the last year of Seleucus' life (SC6–8).

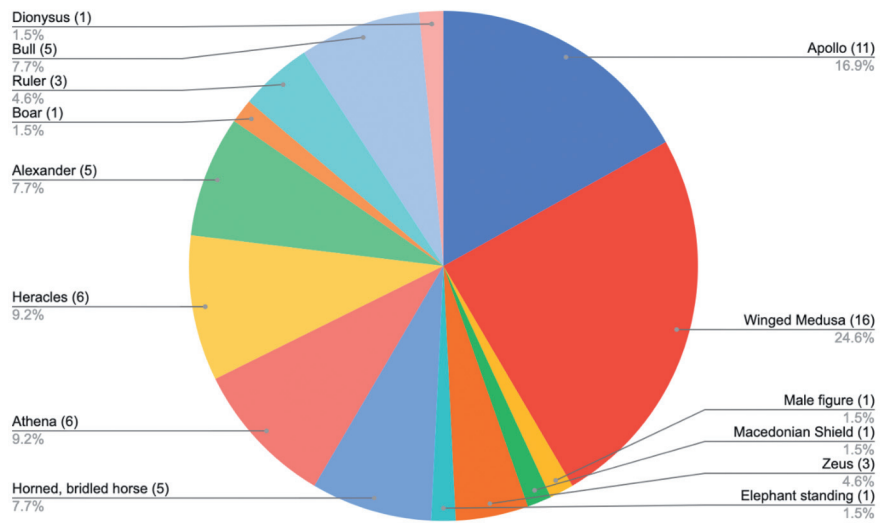


Fig 2: Obverse types and their commonality

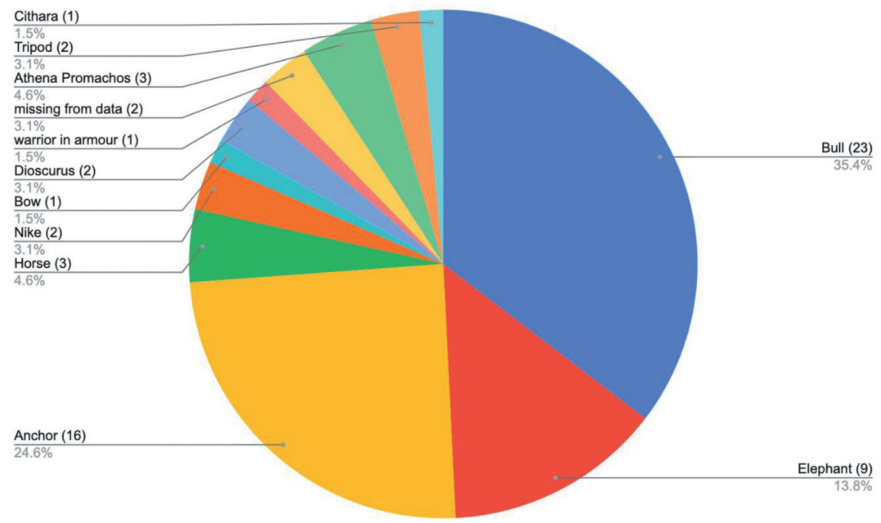


Fig. 3: Reverse types and their commonality

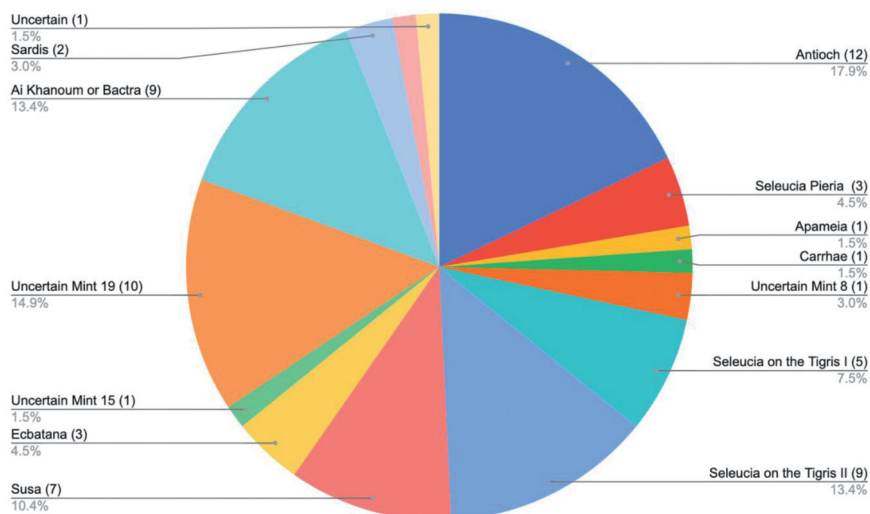


Fig. 4: Mints and the quantity of coin types

The symbolism of the bull can be divided into three main areas, the first being linked to an episode in the personal history of Seleucus: during a sacrifice at which Alexander is present, he holds a bull back from escaping. Mentions of this tale are present in the writing of several ancient authors and texts.²⁷ Additionally, there is a depiction of Seleucus leading a bull sacrifice on a column capital, discovered near Laodicea-by-the-Sea, from the third or fourth century AD.²⁸ Other interpretations of the bull on Seleucid coin types have been linked to various religious figures and elements from Babylonian, Iranian, and Syrian backgrounds.²⁹ Additionally, the bull can be seen as a generic symbol of strength and virility. Given that there are so many different interpretations of the bull image, one can view it as an ambiguous symbol from which people could read the messages that correlated most strongly with their cultural context. A similar argument has been put forward by Erickson: the religious pluralism envisaged here has a parallel within the later use of Apollo

²⁷ App. Syr. 57.294, *Suda* s.v. Σέλευκος, Lib. Or. 11.92 and Ps.-Callisthenes 2.28. See Ogden (2017), 59, Iossif (2012), 45–68 particularly paragraph 4, and Stoneman (2018), for context on Ps.-Callisthenes.

²⁸ It was discovered 20 km north of Laodicea-by-the-Sea; Ogden (2017), 109. On the image and the identification of Seleucus, see Seyrig (1940), and on the capital in reference to this tale, see Ogden (2011), 90–2.

²⁹ This is best discussed in Hoover (2011).

on the silver coinage of Antiochus and the god's assimilation with Nabû.³⁰ Therefore, it seems likely that Seleucid administrators and those in charge of creating and selecting the imagery for coin types chose the bull image for its multiplicity of meanings. The image of the bull could be read differently by different communities and peoples. The bull within the context of the early Seleucid empire was ambiguous, and could stand for strength, religious piety and possibly also allude to an episode within the life of Seleucus. It was a fitting symbol for the ideology of Seleucid kingship.

The same cannot be said of the symbol of the anchor. The image makes up 24.6 % (16 examples) of surviving reverse types, the second largest share of reverse images. Additionally, it is present within the fields of some coins, and it seems to have served as a later countermark.³¹ The significance of the anchor within a Seleucid numismatic context can be divided into two main areas, both of which relate to the personal history/myth of Seleucus I. The first is the association of the anchor with the king's mythic birth.³² This tale links the image of the anchor with the king's destiny to rule as king. The other is a tentative link to Seleucus' time as navarch of Ptolemy, although this would seemingly not be a strong argument as it would seem unlikely that Seleucus or his administration would wish to reference a time and position in which the king was subservient to Ptolemy.³³ These meanings can only be inferred from much later evidence. However, particularly in relation to the notion of the anchor as a personal symbol of Seleucus, it would seem compelling, given both that it is a later administrative symbol on coinage, and that the anchor is woven into a tale from the account of Euphron of Chalcis by later authors. Thus, the anchor image is less ambiguous than the bull and although the intended meaning of the anchor is not entirely clear, it would appear that the anchor during this period was intended to be a personal symbol of Seleucus' authority.

³⁰ On this, see Erickson (2019), especially Ch. 2, and for more on Nabû, see Green (1992), 34. It is also worth noting that Seleucus was the first ruler to ever mint bronze for use in Babylonia; Newell (1978), 61 and Hoover (2011), 207. On the Babylonian evidence for the adoption of bronze over time, see Monerie (2020), 11–16.

³¹ E.g. SC15 and SC35; see Houghton and Lorber (2002), 19 and 25 respectively. On countermarks, see Seyrig (1958), 188. I have not included countermark images of the anchor in my analysis given that they are secondary images next to the main image and they are sometimes difficult to detect on the surfaces of coins.

³² This story seems to have its origins in the account of Euphron of Chalcis (F119 Lightfoot), without mention of the anchor; Ogden (2017), 25–26. The anchor is then a symbol added to the tale by Just. and App., see Just. Epit. 15.4.2–9 and App. Syr. 56.284–285.

³³ Antela-Bernardez (2009), 606 and Winnicki (1989), 82 for discussion of the anchor as a reference to an episode in App. and Erickson (2019), 48 especially n. 88.

These images are then combined and adopted in the minting in the east under Antiochus. There are five coin types that depict an image of a bull on the obverse (these are the only types that portray the bull on the obverse), and an image of an anchor on the reverse (SC284–288). The five coin types all come from Ai Khanoum or Bactra, and are all dated on the basis of their reverse legend (which name the kings Seleucus and Antiochus) to the years between 285 and 281 BC (see reverse legends listed as J. and K.). The coinage of this region is particularly illuminating in terms of the creation of a Seleucid ideology: we see the emergence of a model of legitimacy, and we see the transition of agency from father to son. Antiochus takes the established imagery of his father's bronze coin types and turns the specific into the dynastic and the ambiguous into the imperial. This creation of a dynastic rather than individual model of legitimacy can be viewed as coherent given how it blends into other aspects of the creation of Seleucid dynasty by Antiochus. Antiochus is the only one of the pair of kings at this time that creates a sense of the duality of monarchy through reverse legends (as mentioned above). Additionally, other aspects of the creation of a Seleucid era and dynasty occurred under the later sole rule of Antiochus, for example, evidence of the creation of Apollo as the ancestral god of the dynasty, and the continuation of Seleucus' year count by Antiochus.³⁴

Therefore, Antiochus intentionally creates a sense of dynasty and emphasises the dual kingship within the reverse legends in the east, this can be viewed as part of the construction of the Seleucid dynasty and imperial power. There is an emphasis on the continual and collective dynastic power rather than that of a personal and individual monarch. These images of bull and anchor are no longer symbols of just Seleucus' power but relate to the power of Antiochus as well; the nature of authority reflected on bronze shifts from Seleucus' personal authority to Seleucid dynastic authority. Thus, through the study of bronze coin types and their minting patterns we can track the creation of Seleucid imperial ideology. Additionally, through the study of bronze types we can track the shifts in the minting patterns of Seleucus in the East, and how Antiochus interacts with and reactions to these minting patterns.

Through the close study of Seleucid bronze coin types we can track the creation and development of Seleucid authority and royal ideology. Bronze coin types are particularly helpful given their nature as reliant on authority, additionally, they were used and viewable by the widest section of the population. Therefore, through study

³⁴ For the earliest evidence of the adoption of Apollo as ancestral god by Antiochus, see *I. Erythrai* 205, with comments by Erickson (2019), especially Ch. 2 and Iossif (2011). On the adoption of Seleucus' year count by Antiochus, see Kosmin (2018), especially part 1. Additionally, see Chrubasik and Stevens (2022), 167 who directly tie the creation of the Seleucid era to the measures of 295/4, and the instigation of co-regency.

of their minting patterns, we can see the patterns that emerge in relation to where and when they were created. As evidenced through the chronology and geography of their creation we can see that the minting of bronze coins spreads in tandem with Seleucid authority. Thus, the ideology of this new power structure is communicated on bronzes as it emerges. Additionally, there is a shift in the ideology of bronze types produced by Seleucus in comparison with those produced by Antiochus. Seleucus legitimises himself through images that are ambiguous and personal, emphasising his own royal title and position as king. Antiochus, through his appropriation of these images, transforms this personal and ambiguous ideology into a dynastic and imperial symbolism. The reverse legends of the bronze coin types of Antiochus name him and Seleucus as kings, creating a sense of continuity and legitimacy. The images of these coins by extension create a sense of imperial unity. The minting patterns of these coin types also illuminate the agency of individual kings. Seleucus continues up until the end of his reign to emphasise his personal power through his reverse legends. Antiochus on the other hand shifts from the personal to the dynastic, his coin types emphasise his relationship to his father's power. They now symbolise the ideology of the Seleucids, rather than just King Seleucus.

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